IRAS importing goods input GST

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On this page:

You must pay GST when you import goods into Singapore, regardless of whether you are GST-registered, unless an exemption, relief, or GST suspension arrangement applies.

How import GST is calculated and collected

Import GST is assessed and collected by Singapore Customs based on the import permit details, including the value of the goods and any duties payable.

GST is charged at 9% on the total of:

CIF value (Cost + Insurance + Freight)

All duties payable (as assessed by Singapore Customs)

Commission and other incidental charges

Example: Calculating import GST

| Item | Amount

| Value of goods | $10,000

| Freight and insurance | $2,000

| CIF value | $12,000

| Add: Customs duty | $3,600

| Taxable value | $15,600

| GST at 9% | $1,404

Payment of import GST

Import GST is payable to Singapore Customs. Depending on the import arrangement, payment may be made through:

Your interbank GIRO arrangement with Singapore Customs;

Your declaring agent's interbank GIRO arrangement with Singapore Customs;

SingPost; or

The courier company.

Note: If you are the rightful importer but another business is named as the importer on the import permit, you cannot claim input tax based on that permit.

You and the wrongly declared importer should inform Singapore Customs of the error with supporting documents. You should obtain a replacement import permit showing your name as the importer. You may then claim the GST paid as input tax, subject to the conditions for claiming input tax. The wrongly declared importer should seek a refund of the GST paid from Singapore Customs.

For more information, refer to Singapore Customs’ webpage, Refund of Duties and GST.

Claiming GST on imports

If you are GST-registered, you can claim back the GST you paid on imports as input tax. You must:

Be listed as the importer on the import permit

Meet the conditions for claiming input tax

Declare the amounts accurately in your GST return (GST F5)

What to declare in GST F5

Box 5 (Total value of taxable purchases): Actual value of the imports as reflected in the import permit

Box 7 (Input tax and refunds claimed): GST amount as reflected in the import permit

When the value of the import in the invoice differs from the import permit

| Scenario | What you must do

| Over-declared import value | Make the following adjustments in your GST return:

Box 5: Correct value of imports from the supplier invoice

Box 7: GST amount from the import permit

| Under-declared import value | Obtain a short payment permit from Singapore Customs and pay the additional GST

Make the following adjustments in your GST return

Box 5: Total value from both permits

Box 7: Total GST from both permits

Claiming GST on re-imported goods

You may be contracted to perform value-adding activities (such as testing, repair or assembly) on goods belonging to:

Local customers (GST-registered or not); or

GST-registered overseas customers.

In some cases, you may send the goods to an overseas subcontractor to carry out part or all of the value-adding activities. When the goods are subsequently re-imported into Singapore, import GST will be payable.

If you satisfy the conditions under section 33B of the GST Act, you may claim the full GST incurred on the re-importation of such goods as your input tax.

For details on the conditions and GST reporting requirements, refer to GST: Claiming of GST on re-import of value-added goods (PDF, 565KB).

When GST on imports is not required

You do not need to pay GST at import if:

The goods qualify for import relief

The goods are investment precious metals (IPM) as they are exempt imports

You are approved under a GST suspension or deferment scheme

The goods land in a Free Trade Zone or are imported directly into a Zero-GST or Licensed Warehouse

Import GST reliefs

Import GST relief for goods imported by air or post

Goods imported by air or post (except liquor and tobacco) are not subject to GST at the point of importation when the CIF value is $400 or less. If the CIF value exceeds $400, import GST is payable to Singapore Customs on the entire amount.

Import GST relief for temporary imports

You can apply to Singapore Customs for GST relief on temporary imports (except liquor and tobacco) for approved purposes such as repair, modification or exhibition, for up to 6 months.

For more information, please visit Singapore Customs' webpage on Temporary Import Scheme or contact Singapore Customs at (+65) 6355 2000.

Import GST exemption

Imports of Investment precious metals (IPM) are exempt from GST. As such, you do not need to pay GST on the importation of IPM, nor declare the imports in your GST return.

However, you must:

Apply for an IPM exemption permit via TradeNet®; and

Maintain relevant documents (e.g. import permit, purchase order, invoice, delivery note) to support the exemption.

For more information, refer to GST: Guide on Exemption of Investment Precious Metals (IPM) (PDF, 389KB).

Errors in exemption permit

| Scenario | What you must do

| GST mistakenly paid on IPM imports | Write to IRAS via myTax Mail with supporting documents showing that the imported goods qualify as IPM.

Upon approval from IRAS, claim the refund in your next GST F5 by reporting the amount in Box 7 (Input tax and refunds claimed)

| Over-declared value or quantity on exemption permit | Email Singapore Customs (customs_vdp@customs.gov.sg) about the mistake

No adjustment to GST return F5 is required

| Under-declared value or quantity on exemption permit | Obtain another exemption permit to declare the shortfall in the value or quantity

No adjustment to GST return F5 is required

Maintain a copy of your correspondence with Singapore Customs as part of your GST record-keeping requirements.

Import GST suspension or deferment schemes

You may import goods without paying GST upfront if you are approved under a GST suspension or deferment scheme. Under these schemes, GST is either suspended at the point of import or deferred and accounted for in your GST return.

Common GST suspension and deferment schemes include:

Major Exporter Scheme (MES)

MES improves cash flow for businesses that import and export goods substantially. If you are under MES, you can import non-dutiable goods with GST suspended. You can also enjoy GST suspension on goods removed from a Zero GST or Licensed warehouse.

You only pay import GST when goods are removed from approved warehouses for local consumption.

What goods are covered:

Goods owned by you or your overseas principal (where you act as a section 33(2) agent or section 33A agent)

Non-dutiable goods you re-import after sending overseas for value-adding activities, if you meet the conditions under section 33B of the GST Act

For more information on the scheme and how to report goods imported under the scheme in your GST return, refer to Major Exporter Scheme.

Errors relating to Major Exporter (ME) permit

| Scenario | What you must do

| Over/under-declared import value on ME permit | You do not need to cancel your ME permit.

Make the following adjustments in your GST return

Box 5: Correct value from supplier invoice

Box 9: Correct value from supplier invoice

| Used ME permit for import of Investment Precious Metals | Email Singapore Customs (customs_vdp@customs.gov.sg) about the mistake

Make the necessary adjustments in your GST return:

Box 5: Reduce the value of taxable purchases.

Box 9: Reduce the value of goods imported under MES/A3PL/other approved schemes.

Keep a copy of your correspondence with Singapore Customs as part of your GST records.

Zero GST/Licensed Warehouse Scheme

Singapore Customs administers the Zero GST (ZG) Warehouse and Licensed Warehouse Schemes.

Under these schemes, GST is suspended when you import non-dutiable goods directly into a ZG or Licensed Warehouse that you operate. Import GST is payable only when the goods are removed from the warehouse for local consumption.

For information on

How to report goods imported under the scheme in your GST return; and

The GST treatment of goods stored in ZG or Licensed Warehouses,

refer to GST Guide for Free Trade Zones, Warehouses and Excise Factories (PDF, 178KB).

For more details on the schemes, refer to the respective Singapore Customs' webpages:

Zero-GST Warehouse Scheme

Licensed Warehouse Schemes

Approved Third Party Logistics Company (3PL) Scheme

This scheme enhances the competitiveness of logistics companies that provide logistics management services for overseas principals using Singapore as a logistics hub.

If you are under the Approved 3PL Scheme, you may import goods with GST suspended. GST suspension also applies to goods removed from approved warehouses under the scheme.

For more information on the scheme and how to report goods imported under the scheme in your GST return, refer to Approved Third Party Logistics Company Scheme.

Import GST Deferment Scheme (IGDS)

If you are approved under IGDS, you may defer payment of import GST until the due date of your GST return. Under the scheme, you are required to file your GST returns on a monthly basis. You will account for the deferred import GST and claim it as input tax in the same GST return.

For more information, refer to Import GST Deferment Scheme.

Approved Contract Manufacturer and Trader (ACMT) Scheme

If you are approved as an ACMT contract manufacturer, you may enjoy import GST suspension for:

Your own goods

Goods belonging to an overseas person where you act as a section 33(2) or section 33A agent

Goods consigned to you by your overseas client for value-adding activities under the ACMT scheme

You may also use your ACMT status to re-import non-dutiable goods belonging to your local customer or GST-registered overseas customer that were previously sent overseas for value-adding activities, if you meet the conditions under section 33B of the GST Act.

For more information on the scheme and how to report goods imported under the scheme, refer to GST: Approved Contract Manufacturer and Trader Scheme (PDF, 1091KB).

Approved Refiner and Consolidator Scheme (ARCS)

The import GST suspension privileges under ARCS depend on whether you are an Approved Refiner or Approved Consolidator.

If you are an Approved Refiner, you may enjoy import GST suspension for:

Your own goods

Goods belonging to an overseas person where you act as a section 33(2) or section 33A agent

Goods consigned to you by your overseas customer for refining into investment precious metals or precious metals

If you are an Approved Consolidator, you may enjoy import GST suspension for:

Your own goods

Goods consigned to you by an overseas customer for refining into investment precious metals or precious metals

You may also use your ARCS status to re-import non-dutiable goods belonging to your local customer or GST-registered overseas customer that were previously sent overseas for value-adding activities, if you meet the conditions under section 33B of the GST Act.

For more information on the scheme and how to report goods imported under the scheme, refer to GST: Approved Refiner and Consolidator Scheme (PDF, 881KB).

Import GST suspension at Free Trade Zones and Zero-GST or Licensed Warehouses

GST may be suspended at import based on the location of the goods, even if you are not approved under a GST suspension or deferment scheme.

Goods temporarily removed from Zero-GST or Licensed Warehouse for auctions and exhibitions

You may remove goods from approved warehouses for purposes such as auctions or exhibitions without paying GST, provided that the goods are returned to the approved warehouse after the auction or exhibition.

If the goods are not returned and are removed for local consumption, GST becomes payable to Singapore Customs.

For more information, refer to Temporary Import Scheme.

Free Trade Zones and transhipments

Free Trade Zones (FTZs) are designated areas in Singapore where GST and customs duty are not payable when goods arrive. You do not need to declare such goods as taxable purchases in your GST return until they cross the duty point and enter customs territory.

For more information, visit Singapore Customs' webpages on import and export procedures.

GST treatment for overseas goods stored in a Free Trade Zone

This section applies to goods from outside Singapore that land in an FTZ pending customs clearance.

If you remove goods from the FTZ into customs territory, GST is payable to Singapore Customs unless you are approved under an import GST suspension or deferment scheme (e.g. MES, Approved 3PL Scheme, ACMT Scheme, ARCS, or IGDS).

If you move goods from one FTZ into another FTZ, or into a Zero-GST or Licensed Warehouse, GST is not payable.

If you remove goods from the FTZ for export (transhipment), GST is not chargeable as the supplies are out-of-scope and need not be reported in your GST return.

If you use or consume goods within the FTZ, GST is payable to Singapore Customs.

If you supply goods within the FTZ and the goods remain in the FTZ, GST is not chargeable as the supplies are out-of-scope and need not be reported in your GST return.

For more information, refer to GST Guide for Free Trade Zones, Warehouses and Excise Factories (PDF, 178KB).

GST treatment for local goods stored in Free Trade Zone

This section applies to locally manufactured goods and goods that have cleared customs control but are stored in an FTZ.

If you remove goods from the FTZ and re-enter customs territory, GST is payable unless Singapore Customs has granted relief.

If you supply goods within the FTZ, GST is chargeable and must be accounted for in your GST return as standard-rated supplies. You may zero-rate supplies intended for export if you maintain the required export evidence as stated in GST: Guide on Exports (PDF, 0.9MB).

For more information, refer to GST Guide for Free Trade Zones, Warehouses and Excise Factories (PDF, 178KB).

Importing on behalf of an overseas principal

You may import goods for an overseas person as their agent under one of the following arrangements:

Section 33(2) agent; or

Section 33A agent.

Section 33(2) agent

You may import and supply goods in Singapore on behalf of an overseas person as a section 33(2) agent. The overseas person must be either:

Not GST-registered; or

GST-registered under the Overseas Vendor Registration (OVR) pay-only regime.

As a section 33(2) agent, you may claim the GST paid on the import of goods (subject to the conditions for claiming input tax).

When you supply the goods:

You make the supply as if you are the principal

If you sell the goods locally, you must charge and account for GST at the standard rate

If you export the goods and maintain the required export evidence, you may zero-rate the supply

You must track all goods and ensure that all goods imported as a section 33(2) agent are supplied, even if the goods change in nature and form.

For the types of export evidence to maintain under each export scenario, refer to GST: Guide on Exports (PDF, 0.9MB) and GST: Guide on Hand-Carried Exports Scheme (PDF, 353KB).

For more information on the requirements for a section 33(2) agent, refer to GST: Guide on Imports (PDF, 436KB).

What to declare in your GST return

You must declare the import and supply of goods on behalf of your overseas principal in your GST return.

You must:

Account for output tax on standard-rated supplies

Claim the GST paid on imports as your input tax (subject to conditions)

Changing agents and transferring goods

The overseas principal may appoint another agent to act on their behalf. As the existing agent, you must transfer the overseas principal’s goods to the newly appointed agent. The new agent will be responsible for charging and accounting for GST on the subsequent sale or disposal of the transferred goods.

You may transfer the goods without repaying the import GST previously claimed, deferred or suspended provided that:

You and the new agent declare that all conditions and obligations set out in sections 5 and 6 of the self-review form "Self-Review of Eligibility and Declaration on the Change of Agent and Transfer of Goods under Section 33(2) of the GST Act" (DOC, 77KB) are satisfied; and

The original declaration form is submitted to IRAS before the date of the transfer.

For more information, refer to GST: Guide on Imports (PDF, 436KB).

Section 33A agent

You may claim the GST paid at the time of import as a section 33A agent if you:

Import goods belonging to an overseas person;

Export the goods without making any further supply of the goods; and

Meet the relevant conditions.

For more information on the requirements for a section 33A agent, refer to GST: Guide on Imports (PDF, 436KB).

Maintaining records as an agent

As an agent, you must maintain sufficient documentary records and evidence relating to the import and supply of goods on behalf of the overseas principal.

You must:

Keep separate records for goods belonging to the overseas principal; and

Comply with the GST record keeping requirements.

If you are under any import GST suspension scheme

If you are approved under an import GST suspension scheme, you may use your scheme status to import non-dutiable goods belonging to your overseas principal either for sale in Singapore or to re-export. GST will be suspended at the point of import.

This applies to schemes such as:

Major Exporter Scheme

Approved Third Party Logistics Company Scheme

Approved Contract Manufacturer and Trader Scheme

Approved Import GST Suspension Scheme

Approved Refiner and Consolidator Scheme

Documents

GST: Guide on Exports (PDF, 936KB)

Documents

GST: Guide on Hand-Carried Exports Scheme (PDF, 480KB)

Documents

GST Guide for Free Trade Zones, Warehouses and Excise Factories (PDF, 435KB)

Documents

GST: Guide on Imports (PDF, 599KB)

Documents

GST: Approved Contract Manufacturer and Trader (ACMT) Scheme (PDF, 456KB)

Documents

GST: Approved Refiner and Consolidator Scheme (ARCS) (PDF, 618KB)

Documents

GST: Guide on Exemption of Investment Precious Metals (IPM) (PDF, 377KB)

Documents

GST: Claiming of GST on re-import of value-added goods (PDF, 365KB)

Documents

Self-Review of Eligibility and Declaration on the Change of Agent and Transfer of Goods under Section 33(2) of the GST Act (DOCX, 86KB)

Pages

Conditions for Claiming Input Tax

Pages

Overseas businesses supplying remote services and low-value goods to Singapore